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From Objective Character Motivation to Learners' Subjective Reconstruction

A Pilot Study on Conceptual Mapping in the Rén Component Family among Spanish-Speaking Learners of Chinese

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Is the Rén component family visually transparent, or cognitively reconstructible?

The Rén component family is historically motivated by the graphic representation of the human figure, but this motivation is not necessarily perceived directly by Spanish-speaking learners.

Research problem

Objective account. Character structure and etymology explain historical motivation.

Learner reconstruction. Learners transform graphic cues into subjective rationales.

Pedagogical implication. Subjective rationales can bridge association and systematic form–meaning understanding.

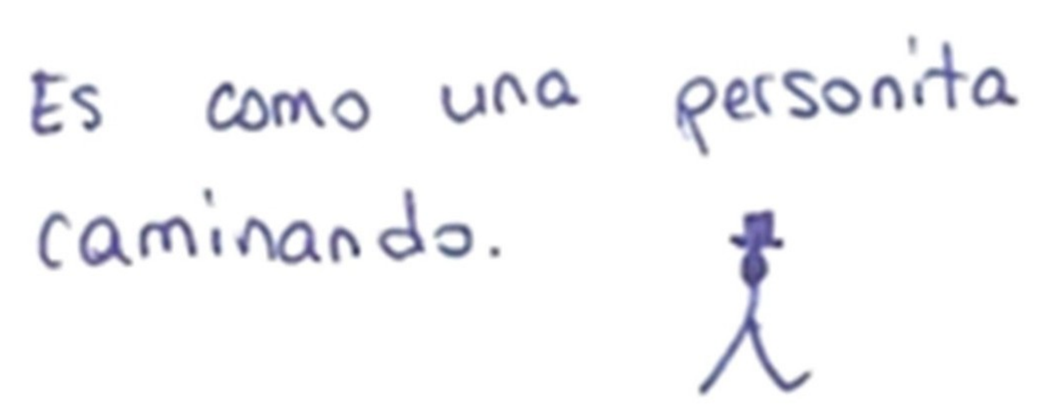
Pilot study

- **Participants:** 9 Spanish-speaking beginner learners of Chinese
- **Task:** open-ended character-form interpretation
- **Focus:** 人 and its component family
- **Data:** exploratory questionnaire responses
- **Analysis:** inductive coding

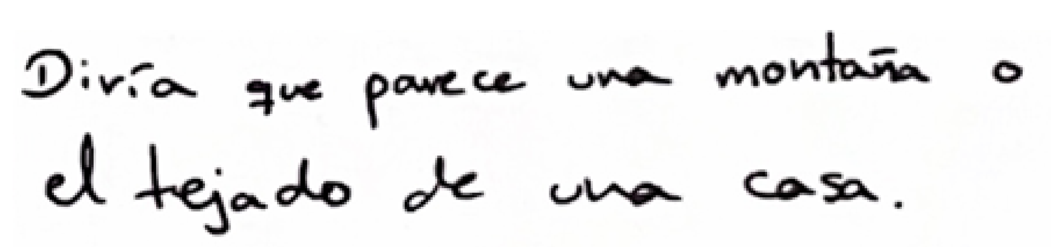
Results: learner interpretations across the Rén component family

象形 Pictographs
人

Perceptual level: the human figure is not fully transparent.
Explanatory level: learners may construct interpretations that approach the traditional pictographic rationale.



"It's like a little person walking."



"I would say it looks like a mountain or the roof of a house."

会意 Associative compounds
休 / 仙 / 坐 / 众

Key pattern: component configurations activate multiple schemas and frames that learners integrate into subjective rationales.

休 / 仙 / 坐 / 众

Schema / frame activation

Embodied schema
休 / 坐
身体姿态：休息 / 坐下
descansa / sentarse
rest / sit

Spatial schema
坐 / 仙
空间关系：地面 / 山
tierra / montaña
ground / mountain

Scene / event frame
休 / 坐
场景事件：树下 / 露营 / 降落
bajo el árbol / acampan / aterrizaje
under a tree / camping / landing

Social schema
众
社会群体：人群 / 家庭 / 部落
muchas personas / familia / tribu
many people / family / tribe

Cultural association
仙
文化联想：加利西亚 / 隐士 / 圣人
gallego / ermitaño / santo
Galician / hermit / saint

Selected responses show how component configurations activate multiple schemas and frames.

形声 Phono-semantic compounds
你 / 什 / 伙

semantic radical → person-related interpretation

semantic-radical dominance

phonetic component ⇢ weakened / reinterpreted

In characters with 亻, persona emerges as the dominant learner association.

Not directly transparent, but cognitively reconstructible

Objective motivation ≠ learner interpretation

Learners reconstruct the Rén component family by mapping graphic cues onto learner knowledge and integrating them into subjective rationales.

Conceptual mapping model

Shared abstract structure: salient person-related cue + co-present element
↓
Interpretable relation / scene / category

Character-form space
人 亻 木 山
休 仙 坐 众
你 什 伙
graphic, componential, and phono-semantic cues

Conceptual mappings

Learner knowledge space
visual analogy
embodied–spatial schemas
social–cultural knowledge
lexical categories
co-component reinterpretation

Cognitive operations
Cue uptake
Association activation
Integrative mapping

Emergent learner-constructed subjective rationale
Pictographs: human figure or competing visual analogy
Associative compounds: embodied, spatial, social, and contextual rationales
Phono-semantic compounds: semantic-radical dominance (亻); phonetic component weakened or reinterpreted

Mechanism, implications and supplement

Mechanism

1. **Non-automatic transparency** — character motivation ≠ learner-perceived motivation
2. **Cue-triggered reconstruction** — whole forms, components, and radicals as triggers
3. **Selective integration** — graphic cues integrated with embodied, spatial, social, and cultural schemas

Teaching implications

- **Etymology is not self-evident** — use learner rationales as a bridge to character-structure explanation
- **Learner rationales as scaffolding** — reveal how graphic form connects with meaning
- **From association to structure** — start from rationales; guard against arbitrary interpretation

Deviations reveal cognitive strategy selection.

Pedagogy should use learner-constructed rationales as scaffolds to make character structure and form–meaning relations explicit.

References

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Scan for poster PDF, references, and contact.

Keywords: Chinese character orthography; Rén component; conceptual mapping; conceptual blending; learner reconstruction; subjective rationale construction; Spanish-speaking learners; Chinese character teaching